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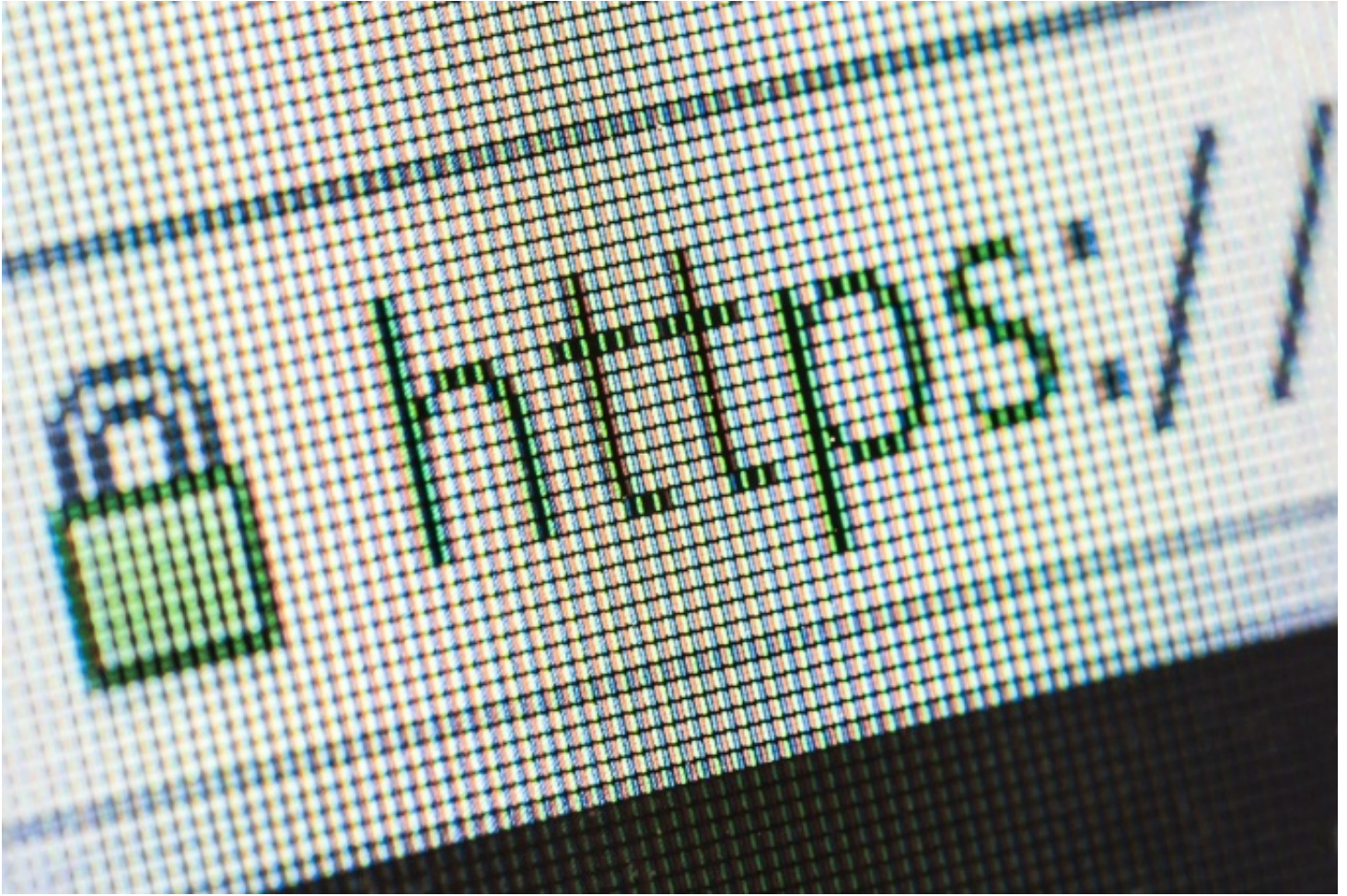
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HTTPS May Be Your Ticket to Boosted Ranking



By **Chaz Wilke**, Staff Writer

July 9, 2015

Google normally chooses ranking signals that benefit the visitors of any given site. Great user experience tends to drive higher rankings in Google's search results. But recently, a new ranking signal has been revealed.

Google is now considering [HTTPS encryption](#) a factor when deciding where your site ranks in its search results.

About HTTPS

Much of the internet as we know it is run on HyperText Transfer Protocol (HTTP). This is a protocol used to create HyperText, which is the basis of most webpages. HyperText can include hyperlinks, those blue underlined, clickable pieces of text that take you to another page or file. It can also include text for reading and markup language also known as HTML.

It is important to understand that HTTPS is HTTP (HyperText Transfer Protocol) plus a SSL (Secure Socket Layer) or the newer TLS (Transport Layer Security) certificate. An answer on StackOverflow.com [explains](#) the nuts and bolts:

"SSL allows arbitrary protocols to be communicated securely. It enables clients to (a) verify that they are indeed communicating with the server they expect and not a man-in-the-middle and (b) encrypt the network traffic so that parties other than the client and server cannot see the communication.

An SSL certificate contains a public key and certificate issuer. Not only can clients use the certificate to communicate with a server, clients can verify that the certificate was cryptographically signed by an official

Certificate Authority. For example, if your browser trusts the VeriSign Certificate Authority, and VeriSign signs my SSL certificate, your browser will inherently trust my SSL certificate."

Within this structure, HTTPS is an encrypted form of transfer protocol that keeps snooping eyes from seeing where you visit and intercepting what you transfer from user to website and vice versa. In short, much of what we don't like about the NSA Internet snooping can be mitigated by enforcing HTTPS on your site. Russell Brandom from The Verge explains the danger of running a site without HTTPS encryption: "As long as sites are unencrypted, it's trivial for attackers to see where you're going online."

Web hosts, Internet service providers, and interested third parties including hackers and government agencies can easily intercept and interpret non-encrypted web traffic. This is now why Google has chosen to give a rankings bump to websites that decide to encrypt the traffic on its pages.



How to get HTTPS encryption on your site

The most important element of achieving HTTPS on your site is to get your site certified with an impartial and verified third party known as a Certificate Authority (CA). Companies like [Symantec](#) and [digicert](#) offer certification for an annual fee. There are also services like [StartSSL](#) that offer free SSL certificates for individual users. This means that if you only have one site to your name, you may be able to sidestep the out of pocket cost to grab the HTTPS certification that Google is now seeking in the sites it populates at the top of its search engine results.

Once a verified third party can assess that you are the owner of your site, you will be issued an SSL or TLS certificate. From there, you need to redirect users and search engines to your new HTTPS page, which can be done with server-side 301 HTTP redirects.

Make sure to operate a relative link structure on your site as opposed to absolute. This means that when you write an <a> tag, keep the protocol instructions off the link. So instead of coding use This helps more than a switch to HTTPS and will help when debugging many common HTML errors you may run into when building and growing your site.

Google advises that you operate your site on a web server that supports and enables HTTP Strict Transport Security (HSTS). This will tell user browsers to automatically request your site's pages using HTTPS even if the user types http when typing your site's URL.

Once that is all complete, it's just a matter of having the Google crawler index your site with the updated certification.

Takeaway

Now that Google is upfront about offering a rankings incentive for those who switch to HTTPS, there is no better time to explore the potential of an encrypted web. No matter where you stand on the privacy debate, it seems Google is incentivizing those who make the jump.

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Hailing from Chicago and a product of the Illinois public school system, Chaz Wilke is a professional writer who has written for newspaper, TV, radio, video games, blogs, and film. In his spare time, Chaz enjoys hiking and discovering the hidden gems and oddities of Los Angeles. He also juggles.

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